Web Design MART 341
FINAL

Sustainable Eats

A Reflective Analysis of Web Design, Interaction, and Sustainability

By Mya Stenson

Over the past three months, I've been developing *Sustainable Eats* —a web project dedicated to sustainable cooking, reducing food waste, and encouraging thoughtful conversations around eco-conscious living. What began as a class assignment quickly turned into something much more personal. With each design phase and round of reflection, I not only honed my web development skills, but also came to see how powerful digital spaces can be for creating real-world impact. The site I've built is not only functional and visually intentional—it reflects my journey as a designer and my genuine passion for sustainability.

In the early stages, I focused on layout and balance. Setting the .content div to 80% width and centering it with margin: 0 auto; instantly made the content more approachable. It helped reduce that overwhelming wall-of-text feel on wider screens. I chose a soft background color (#f0f8ff) to evoke a light, calming, nature-inspired vibe. To add visual interest without clutter, I floated an image to the right of the "Featured Recipes" list using CSS, which helped the page feel fresh and dynamic. This visual groundwork really set the tone for the rest of the site.

As the project evolved, so did my vision. I added more pages—a homepage, a recipe submission page, and a featured recipe post (my vegetarian lasagna!). I leaned heavily on HTML5 and CSS to ensure each page felt cohesive and consistent. One of my favorite elements to build was the submission form, which uses a mailto: action. It's simple, but it offers an easy way for visitors to share their sustainable recipes. Next to the form, I added a table with food waste statistics to ground the mission of the site in real-world relevance.

A major turning point was adding a community forum. With mock discussions and threaded replies, the site shifted from a one-way information platform to a space where people could interact. I layered in a looping header video with a text overlay to give the forum page energy and warmth right off the bat. I also embedded a real-time weather widget—to encourage eco-friendly outdoor activities—and linked to outside resources through a “Gardening Tips” button. These details helped the site become not just informative, but vibrant and community-driven.

Accessibility and styling were priorities throughout. I organized media files into a dedicated folder and made sure all images had alt text or descriptions. I stuck to a consistent color palette and used responsive design techniques so the site would look great on any device. I played with hover effects, gradients, and soft animations to add interactivity while keeping the experience intuitive. The contact page was a standout moment for me—it featured box shadows, centered text, and thoughtful font choices. Feedback from classmates during peer reviews pushed me to take more creative risks with my CSS.

Typography was another area where I really got to express the site’s personality. I paired the friendly, clean look of ‘Poppins’ with the elegance of ‘Georgia’ for headings. I used CSS pseudo-elements like h2::before to add fun visual touches—like a little sprouting seedling before section titles. These small design choices especially came to life on the About page, where I introduced myself as the creator and shared what inspired me to build *Sustainable Eats* .

That said, the journey wasn’t without its challenges. Getting layouts to work seamlessly across desktop and mobile took a lot of trial and error. I learned how to troubleshoot float issues, tweak margins, and adjust breakpoints for better flexibility. It was also a balancing act to organize content in a way that encouraged exploration without overwhelming the user. Using semantic HTML, streamlined navigation, and a clean file structure helped me find that balance.

Looking ahead, I have big plans. The top priority is building a proper backend so the site can dynamically manage recipe submissions. That would open the door for cool features like recipe ratings, filters, and showcasing new contributions in real time. I'd also love to bring in more JavaScript functionality—for things like expanding forum threads or validating form inputs on the fly. These next steps would take the site from great to truly interactive.

In the end, *Sustainable Eats* became more than a school project—it became an expression of my values, skills, and creativity. From basic layout tweaks to a full-blown multi-page experience with community and educational features, I've learned so much about how to design with heart and intention. This project reaffirmed my love for digital tools and my commitment to sustainability. And honestly? It made me excited to keep learning, building, and making a difference—online and off.